

Political Distrust and Anti-Immigration Attitudes in Europe

Mauricio Sierra

Abstract

Political distrust has become an increasingly prominent feature of contemporary European politics alongside the rise of exclusionary and anti-immigration attitudes. This paper examines whether individuals who distrust political institutions are more likely to express anti-immigration attitudes across Europe. Using data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS), the analysis constructs indices of political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes from multiple survey items. The study employs ordinary least squares regression models with demographic controls, ideological controls, survey weights, and country fixed effects. The results show a consistent positive association between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes. Individuals with higher levels of distrust toward political institutions are significantly more likely to hold exclusionary attitudes toward immigration, even after accounting for ideology, education, age, and cross-national differences. The findings contribute to research on political distrust, democratic dissatisfaction, and backlash politics in contemporary Europe.

1. Introduction

Across Europe, declining trust in political institutions has become one of the defining features of contemporary democratic politics. At the same time, immigration has emerged as a highly polarizing political issue shaping electoral competition, party systems, and public opinion across European democracies. The simultaneous rise of political distrust and exclusionary attitudes toward immigration has fueled broader debates about democratic dissatisfaction, populism, and backlash politics. Understanding how distrust toward political institutions relates to anti-immigration attitudes is therefore increasingly important for explaining contemporary political behavior in Europe.

Existing research has linked anti-immigration attitudes to a variety of social, economic, and cultural factors, including educational attainment, ideological orientation, economic insecurity, and identity-based concerns. Similarly, a large literature on political distrust and democratic dissatisfaction has examined declining confidence in political institutions and its consequences for democratic legitimacy and political behavior. More recently, scholarship on populism and backlash politics has emphasized how distrust toward political elites and institutions may become connected to exclusionary and anti-immigration attitudes. Individuals who perceive political institutions as unresponsive or detached from ordinary citizens may become more receptive to narratives emphasizing national protection, cultural threat, and opposition to immigration.

This paper examines whether individuals with higher levels of political distrust are more likely to express anti-immigration attitudes across Europe. Using data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS), the analysis constructs indices of political distrust and anti-immigration

attitudes using multiple survey items. The empirical analysis employs ordinary least squares (OLS) regression models with demographic controls, ideological controls, survey weights, and country fixed effects.

The results demonstrate a consistent positive association between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes. Individuals with higher levels of distrust toward political institutions are significantly more likely to hold exclusionary attitudes toward immigration, even after accounting for age, education, gender, ideology, and cross-national differences. These findings contribute to broader debates on political distrust, democratic dissatisfaction, and backlash politics in contemporary Europe.

The paper proceeds as follows. The next section reviews the literature on political distrust, backlash politics, and immigration attitudes and develops the paper's theoretical expectations. The third section describes the data, variables, and empirical strategy. The fourth section presents the results of the statistical analysis. The final section discusses the implications and limitations of the findings.

2. Political Distrust, Backlash Politics, and Immigration Attitudes

Political distrust has become a central concern in the study of contemporary democratic politics. Research on democratic dissatisfaction has documented declining levels of confidence in political institutions, political parties, and elected representatives across many advanced democracies (Dalton, 2004; Norris, 2011). Political distrust is generally understood as a perception that political institutions and political elites are unresponsive, ineffective, or disconnected from ordinary citizens. While some scholars argue that distrust may reflect healthy democratic skepticism, persistent distrust can also weaken democratic legitimacy and increase support for anti-establishment political actors (Hetherington, 1998).

At the same time, immigration has become one of the most politically salient issues in Europe. A large literature on immigration attitudes has identified several factors associated with exclusionary or anti-immigration preferences, including educational attainment, ideological orientation, economic insecurity, and identity-related concerns (Hainmueller and Hopkins, 2014; Ceobanu and Escandell, 2010). In particular, research consistently finds that individuals with lower levels of education and stronger right-wing ideological orientations are more likely to express opposition toward immigration and multiculturalism.

More recently, scholarship on populism and backlash politics has emphasized the relationship between distrust toward political institutions and exclusionary political attitudes. Populist discourse frequently combines criticism of political elites with narratives emphasizing national protection, cultural threat, and opposition to immigration (Mudde, 2004; Mudde and Rovira Kaltwasser, 2017). Norris and Inglehart (2019) argue that cultural backlash dynamics have contributed to the rise of anti-establishment and exclusionary political attitudes across Western democracies. Similarly, Inglehart and Norris (2016) suggest that political reactions against social and cultural change have strengthened support for populist and nationalist political movements in Europe and the United States.

Within this broader literature, political distrust may contribute to anti-immigration attitudes through several mechanisms. First, individuals who distrust political institutions may perceive political elites as incapable of managing immigration effectively. Second, distrust may increase

receptiveness to anti-establishment narratives portraying immigration as evidence of elite failure or political detachment from ordinary citizens. Third, distrust may reinforce broader perceptions of cultural and political threat that become connected to exclusionary attitudes toward immigrants and minority groups.

At the same time, political distrust does not operate independently from other important predictors of immigration attitudes. Ideological orientation remains one of the strongest predictors of exclusionary political attitudes in Europe, with right-wing individuals generally expressing stronger opposition toward immigration. Education is also consistently associated with immigration attitudes, as higher educational attainment is often linked to greater support for immigration and multiculturalism (Hainmueller and Hopkins 2014). Age and other demographic characteristics may additionally shape both immigration attitudes and confidence in political institutions.

This paper builds on these literatures by examining whether political distrust remains associated with anti-immigration attitudes after accounting for demographic and ideological factors. Using data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS), the analysis investigates whether individuals who distrust political institutions are systematically more likely to express exclusionary attitudes toward immigration across Europe.

Based on the existing literature, the paper proposes two main hypotheses:

- H1: Individuals with higher levels of political distrust will express stronger anti-immigration attitudes.
- H2: Individuals with more right-wing ideological orientations will express stronger anti-immigration attitudes.

These hypotheses are tested using ordinary least squares regression models with demographic controls, survey weights, and country fixed effects.

3. Data and Methods

This paper uses data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey (ESS), a cross-national survey that collects nationally representative data on political attitudes and social behavior across European countries. The ESS is particularly well suited for the study of political distrust and immigration attitudes because it includes standardized measures of political trust, ideology, and attitudes toward immigration across multiple European contexts.

The unit of analysis is the individual respondent. The analysis includes respondents from all available countries in ESS Round 11 with valid responses on the relevant variables. Survey weights provided by the ESS are used in the main regression models to improve cross-national representativeness.

The dependent variable is an index measuring anti-immigration attitudes. The index is constructed using three ESS survey items measuring whether respondents believe immigration is good or bad for the economy, whether immigration enriches or undermines cultural life, and whether immigration makes the country a better or worse place to live. The original scales were reverse coded so that higher values indicate stronger anti-immigration attitudes. The final index was calculated as the average of the three items.

The main independent variable is an index measuring political distrust. The index combines three survey items measuring trust in parliament, trust in politicians, and trust in political parties. The original trust variables were reverse coded so that higher values indicate higher levels of political distrust. The final index was calculated as the average of the three items.

The analysis also includes several control variables commonly associated with immigration attitudes in the political behavior literature. These include age, gender, educational attainment, and left-right ideological self-placement. Ideological orientation is measured using the ESS left-right self-placement scale, where higher values indicate more right-wing ideological positions.

The empirical analysis proceeds in several stages. First, descriptive statistics and visualizations are used to examine the distribution of the main variables and the relationship between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes. Second, ordinary least squares (OLS) regression models are estimated to evaluate whether political distrust is associated with anti-immigration attitudes. The models are estimated progressively by first examining the bivariate relationship and then introducing demographic and ideological controls. Additional models incorporate survey weights and country fixed effects to account for cross-national variation across European countries.

Although the analysis identifies significant associations between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes, the study remains observational and cross-sectional. Consequently, the findings should not be interpreted as establishing causal relationships. Instead, the results identify systematic empirical associations between political distrust and exclusionary attitudes in contemporary Europe.

4. Results

The empirical analysis reveals a consistent positive relationship between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes across Europe. Figure 1 presents the bivariate relationship between the political distrust index and the anti-immigration index. The fitted regression line indicates that individuals with higher levels of distrust toward political institutions tend to express stronger anti-immigration attitudes. Although individual responses vary considerably, the overall pattern suggests a clear positive association between the two variables.

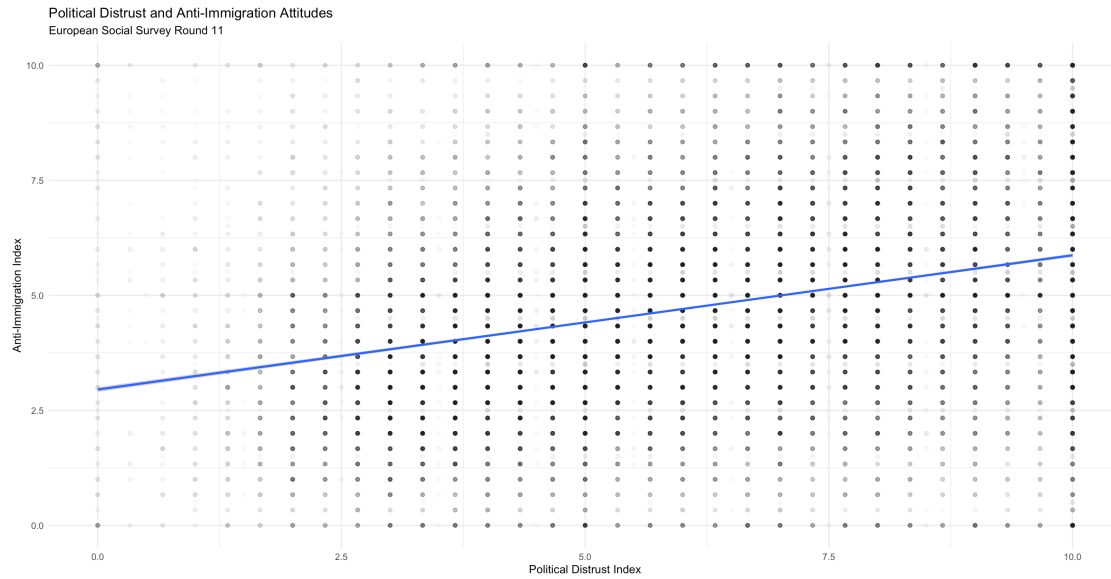


Figure 1. Relationship Between Political Distrust and Anti-Immigration Attitudes in Europe (ESS Round 11)

To evaluate this relationship more systematically, the analysis estimates a series of ordinary least squares (OLS) regression models. Table 1 presents the main regression results. Across all model specifications, political distrust remains a strong and statistically significant predictor of anti-immigration attitudes with anti-immigration attitudes.

	Baseline Model	Country Fixed Effects
(Intercept)	1.131*** (0.055)	1.534*** (0.087)
distrust_index	0.260*** (0.004)	0.279*** (0.004)
agea	0.012*** (0.001)	0.011*** (0.000)
gndr	0.029 (0.020)	0.023 (0.019)
eisced	-0.054*** (0.003)	-0.044*** (0.002)
lrscale	0.262*** (0.004)	0.248*** (0.004)
Num.Obs.	41917	41917
R2	0.168	0.240
R2 Adj.	0.168	0.239
AIC	210226.7	206525.7
BIC	210287.2	206836.9
Log.Lik.	-105106.326	-103226.847
RMSE	2.13	1.99

+ p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001

Table 1. OLS Regression Models Predicting Anti-Immigration Attitudes

The weighted baseline model indicates that political distrust is strongly associated with anti-immigration attitudes even after controlling for demographic characteristics and ideological self-placement. Substantively, a one-unit increase in political distrust is associated with an increase of approximately 0.26 points in the anti-immigration index. The relationship remains highly statistically significant across all estimated models.

The strongest specification incorporates country fixed effects to account for cross-national differences across European countries. Even after accounting for country-level variation, political distrust remains strongly associated with anti-immigration attitudes. In the country fixed effects model, a one-unit increase in political distrust is associated with an increase of approximately 0.28 points in the anti-immigration index. The persistence of the relationship across model specifications suggests that the association between distrust and exclusionary attitudes is not solely driven by demographic composition, ideological orientation, or country-level differences.

The analysis also identifies several important control variable relationships consistent with existing political behavior research. Right-wing ideological orientation is strongly associated with anti-immigration attitudes across all models. Individuals who place themselves further to the political right are substantially more likely to express exclusionary attitudes toward immigration. Educational attainment is negatively associated with anti-immigration attitudes, indicating that individuals with higher levels of education tend to express more favorable attitudes toward immigration. Age is positively associated with anti-immigration attitudes, while gender does not display a statistically significant relationship in the estimated models.

The inclusion of country fixed effects substantially improves overall model fit. The adjusted R-squared increases from approximately 0.17 in the weighted baseline model to approximately 0.24 in the country fixed effects specification. This suggests that national political and social contexts explain an important share of variation in immigration attitudes across Europe.

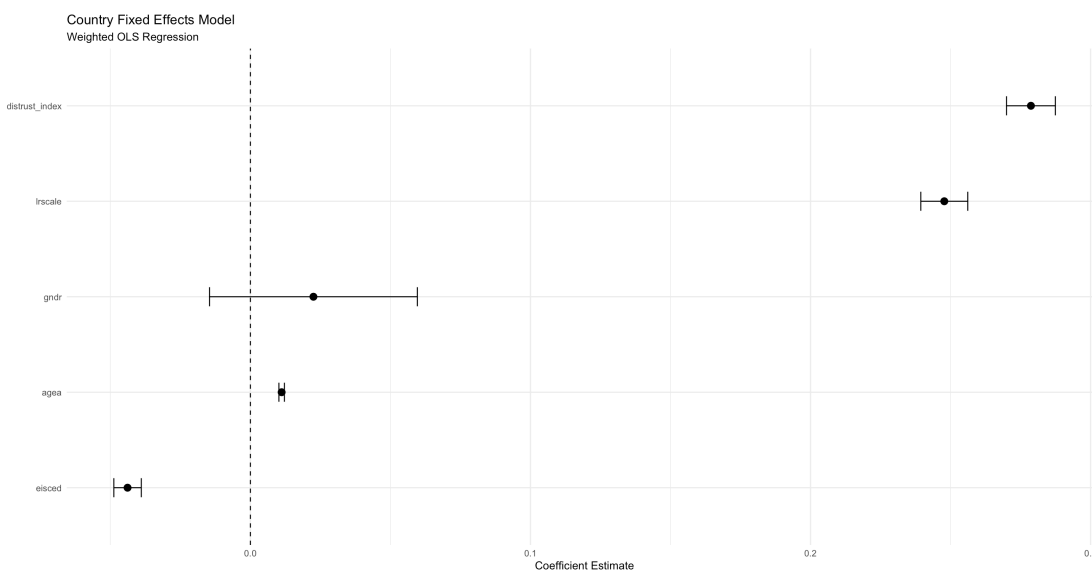


Figure 2. Estimated Coefficients from the Weighted Country Fixed Effects Model

Figure 2 presents the estimated coefficients from the country fixed effects model. The coefficient plot illustrates that political distrust and right-wing ideological orientation are among the strongest positive predictors of anti-immigration attitudes in the analysis. Overall, the findings support both hypotheses proposed in the paper and are consistent with broader research on political distrust, backlash politics, and exclusionary political behavior in contemporary Europe.

5. Conclusion

This paper examined the relationship between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes across Europe using data from Round 11 of the European Social Survey. Building on research on democratic dissatisfaction, backlash politics, and political behavior, the analysis investigated whether individuals with higher levels of distrust toward political institutions are more likely to express exclusionary attitudes toward immigration.

The findings demonstrate a consistent positive association between political distrust and anti-immigration attitudes across all estimated models. Individuals who express higher levels of distrust toward parliament, politicians, and political parties are significantly more likely to hold anti-immigration attitudes, even after accounting for age, gender, educational attainment, ideological self-placement, survey weights, and country-level differences. The persistence of this relationship across multiple model specifications suggests that political distrust is independently associated with exclusionary political attitudes in contemporary Europe.

The analysis also identified several patterns consistent with previous research on political behavior and immigration attitudes. Right-wing ideological orientation was strongly associated with anti-immigration attitudes, while higher levels of educational attainment were associated with more favorable attitudes toward immigration. Additionally, the inclusion of country fixed effects substantially improved model fit, indicating that national political and social contexts play an important role in shaping immigration attitudes across Europe.

At the same time, the study has several limitations. First, the analysis relies on cross-sectional survey data and therefore cannot establish causal relationships between political distrust and immigration attitudes. Political distrust may contribute to exclusionary attitudes, but anti-immigration attitudes may also reinforce distrust toward political institutions. Second, the analysis focuses primarily on individual-level survey responses and does not directly incorporate contextual variables such as economic conditions, immigration levels, or party systems. Future research could extend the analysis by incorporating longitudinal data, multilevel models, or additional measures of populist attitudes and democratic dissatisfaction.

Despite these limitations, the findings contribute to broader debates on democratic dissatisfaction and backlash politics in Europe. The results suggest that distrust toward political institutions is associated not only with declining democratic confidence, but also with exclusionary political attitudes toward immigration. As distrust and political polarization continue to shape European politics, understanding the relationship between institutional distrust and exclusionary attitudes remains important for the study of contemporary political behavior.

6. Bibliography

1. Dalton, Russell J. 2004. *Democratic Challenges, Democratic Choices: The Erosion of Political Support in Advanced Industrial Democracies*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

2. Ceobanu, Alin M., and Xavier Escandell. 2010. "Comparative Analyses of Public Attitudes Toward Immigrants and Immigration Using Multinational Survey Data." *Annual Review of Sociology* 36: 309–328. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev.soc.012809.102651>
3. European Social Survey European Research Infrastructure (ESS ERIC). 2025. *ESS Round 11 Data (2023/24)*. Data file edition 1.0. Sikt - Norwegian Agency for Shared Services in Education and Research.
4. Hainmueller, Jens, and Daniel J. Hopkins. 2014. "Public Attitudes Toward Immigration." *Annual Review of Political Science* 17(1): 225–249. <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-polisci-102512-194818>
5. Hetherington, Marc J. 1998. "The Political Relevance of Political Trust." *American Political Science Review* 92(4): 791–808. <https://doi.org/10.2307/2586304>
6. Inglehart, Ronald, and Pippa Norris. 2016. "Trump, Brexit, and the Rise of Populism: Economic Have-Nots and Cultural Backlash." Harvard Kennedy School Faculty Research Working Paper Series No. RWP16-026.
7. Mudde, Cas. 2004. "The Populist Zeitgeist." *Government and Opposition* 39(4): 541–563. <https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1477-7053.2004.00135.x>
8. Mudde, Cas, and Cristóbal Rovira Kaltwasser. 2017. *Populism: A Very Short Introduction*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.
9. Norris, Pippa. 2011. *Democratic Deficit: Critical Citizens Revisited*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
10. Norris, Pippa, and Ronald Inglehart. 2019. *Cultural Backlash: Trump, Brexit, and Authoritarian Populism*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.
11. Rooduijn, Matthijs. 2018. "What Unites the Voter Bases of Populist Parties? Comparing the Electorates of 15 Populist Parties." *European Political Science Review* 10(3): 351–368. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1755773917000145>